

Field Guide to Public Health Careers

Ten trailheads into one big field — pick one path to explore



Public health is a **team sport** — no single job covers it all. Some careers work with numbers, some work in a lab, some work outdoors, and some work directly with people. Skim all ten trailheads below, then pick **one** profession to research in depth: find its typical education, training, and experience path, and be ready to discuss what you learned with your counselor.

Epidemiologist

Tracks how diseases start and spread, and investigates outbreaks like a health detective.

School: Bachelor's + MPH (often required)
Credential: None required; CPH cert. common
Entry path: ~6 yrs school

Biostatistician / Data Analyst

Turns health data into evidence — finding patterns that guide policy and programs.

School: Bachelor's in stats/math; MPH or MS common
Credential: None required; SAS/R skills valued
Entry path: 4-6 yrs school

Public Health Informatician

Builds and manages the systems that move health data safely — disease reporting, immunization registries, and more.

School: Bachelor's in health informatics/CS; MPH/MS common
Credential: None required; CPH cert. common
Entry path: ~4-6 yrs school

Environmental Health Specialist

Inspects water, air, and waste systems to keep environmental hazards in check.

School: Bachelor's in env./public health
Credential: Registered Sanitarian (RS/RENS) license
Entry path: ~4 yrs school + exam

Public Health Nurse

Runs vaccine clinics, home visits, and community health programs directly with families.

School: Nursing degree (BSN typical)
Credential: RN license (required)
Entry path: ~4 yrs school + boards

Health Educator

Designs programs that teach communities how to prevent disease and stay well.

School: Bachelor's in health education/promotion
Credential: CHES certification common
Entry path: ~4 yrs school + exam

Public Health Physician

A doctor who shapes population-wide health policy instead of (or alongside) treating patients.

School: Bachelor's + Medical school (MD/DO)
Credential: Medical license; board certification
Entry path: ~11-14 yrs school

Food Safety Inspector

Checks restaurants, farms, and plants to stop foodborne illness before it starts.

School: Bachelor's in food science/health
Credential: State inspector certification
Entry path: ~4 yrs school + training

Emergency Preparedness Coordinator

Plans how a community responds to disasters, outbreaks, and other public health emergencies.

School: Bachelor's; MPH often preferred
Credential: FEMA/ICS certifications common
Entry path: ~4-6 yrs school

Public Health Lab Scientist

Tests samples for pathogens and toxins to confirm diagnoses and catch outbreaks early.

School: Bachelor's in medical/clinical lab science
Credential: ASCP certification common
Entry path: ~4 yrs school + cert exam

YOUR ASSIGNMENT — REQUIREMENT 8

Choose Your Own Trail

Pick ONE public health profession that interests you — from this map or one you find on your own.

- 1 Find the **education** it requires (degree & major).
- 2 Find the **training or licensing** it requires.
- 3 Find the **experience** expected to get hired.
- 4 Discuss what you learned with your counselor.

Map Key

- School** — the typical degree path
- Credential** — license or certification needed
- Entry path** — rough years of schooling before an entry-level role